Fathers and Mothers – A Collection

By Sarah Freligh

Our Fathers

Our fathers rise at five and whistle out the door carrying thermoses of black coffee and lunches our mothers have packed for them—bags of corn chips and sandwiches made of meat and cheese. Our mothers tuck notes into the wrap of waxed paper.

◊

Weekends our fathers box-step us around the living room or somersault us from their shoulders into the deep end of a swimming pool. Sometimes our fathers will lock themselves away and listen to the Tigers on the radio or slide under cars until they're called to wash up for dinner.

◊

Our fathers are men. What our mothers say when we ask why our fathers never cook or change diapers. Restless men, they say. Later they'll say it with rolled eyes. *Men*, they will say. Our only inheritance.

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INTRODUCTION

Parents, whether they are biological, adopted, step-parents or a parental figure you chose; they become your anchors -- calm voices in a sea of doubt, beacons of love.

And losing them, regardless of how old you are when that happens, is "something like driving through a plate-glass window. You didn't know it was there until it shattered. And for years to come, you're picking up the pieces, down to the last glassy splinter." ***– Saul Bellow, Nobel Prize for Literature***

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On summer nights our fathers gather with other fathers in back yards to drink and bitch about the foreman, the infernal factory clatter. They brag about the muscle cars they're building, the flex and thrum of their big engines.

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Some of our fathers die drunk in head-ons or face down on the factory floor, their rotted hearts knotted as pine trees. Some of our fathers carry their coffins and try not to cry.

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Our fathers circle the padlocked gate of the Ford plant carrying signs they shake at the scabs who have stolen their jobs. Our fathers walk in snow and rain, raise clenched fists at the cars that honk past them. They stay out late drinking beer, roll home long after we're in bed.

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Our fathers are shut down, laid off. They drink beer from cans that they crush in their hands and leave on the coffee table for us to clean up. Our mothers tiptoe around our fathers, steer clear of their simmer and filth. They whisper over the slosh of the dishwasher about how hard it is for a man not to work.

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After the Ford plant closes, our fathers go back to school at night. Shaved raw and choked by neckties, they stare down the glare of computer screens. Other fathers disappear into the dark bars downtown, lit by the flicker of TV screens and the thunder of fights.

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We grow up, go away, marry men who are not our fathers, men with soft hands and clean fingernails. Men who read stories to their daughters about cloth rabbits and moons and spiders that die alone.

◊

Our fathers get old and then older. Soon enough they're headlights on a wall, there and gone. Shadows, then ghosts.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sarah Freligh
ISBN: On-Line Magazine
https://www.cleavermagazine.com/our-fathers-by-sarah-freligh/
Publisher: Cleaver Magazine.com
Date (Month/Year): September 23, 2021

So I Call My Mother On Sunday

So I call my mother on Sunday
every Sunday, though I don't say
how are you anymore because I know
she's dying and each day will be worse
than the day before. Her liver's rotting
the way an apple goes bad, swelling
as it softens and maybe smells sweet
as fruit does before you toss it.
I ask her how the weather is, snowing
like crazy here, about the traffic
at the bird feeder. She likes to watch
the small birds, chickadees and nuthatches,
not so much the sparrows though
today she says the minister's there
and she's planning her funeral. She wants
to be cremated. She wants an urn
and the family to bury her, no one else
in attendance. A memorial service, maybe
sandwiches after. It's been snowing
every day for a week now, I say, we're knee
deep in it. Did you hear me, she says
and I tell her it's such heavy snow
to shovel every hour I get so tired
of shoveling, god, I want to cry.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sarah Freligh
ISBN: On-Line Transcript
https://sapphostorque.com/2017/04/09/poem-a-day-sarah-freligh/
Publisher: Sapphos Torque.com
Date (Month/Year): April 9, 2017

from The Beginning of Something is Always the End of Another

. . . .I know this will end in ashes

at a cemetery where we stood
over my mother's urn, hugless, useless

hands dangling from our dumb arms
while on the hill above us a guy wearing

soiled khakis lounged in a golf cart,
waiting for us to understand this was it,

the end, we needed to leave already
so he could finally begin to dig.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sarah Freligh
Book: Sad Math
ISBN: 978-0913785645
Publisher: Moon City Press
Date (Month/Year): Dec 2015

Safe

After we buried my mother, we

told stories in the room where she'd died.

The hospital bed was gone, the love

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seat tucked flush with the window again, long

sofa shoved against the wall like always, the same

sofa where she'd fall asleep watching baseball

while she waited for me to come home from

some high-school date, and once, when I wasn't

home by midnight, she threw a raincoat

over her flannel pajamas and drove around

until she found me behind the Big Boy

with the second-string quarterback. All the way

home and for an entire week, I was punished

by silence, a vast black void of disgust.

The last time I saw her, I wanted her to speak to me,

to lock the front door and turn off the last

light, to follow me upstairs, having made

the house safe for the night. But she didn't

know who I was.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sarah Freligh
ISBN: On-Line Magazine
https://www.thesunmagazine.org/issues/440/selected-poems-sarah-freligh-issue-440
Publisher: The Sun Magazine.org
Date (Month/Year): Issue 440. August 2012

Wondrous

I'm driving home from school when the radio talk
turns to E.B. White, his birthday, and I exit
the here and now of the freeway at rush hour,

travel back into the past, where my mother is reading
to my sister and me the part about Charlotte laying her
eggs
and dying, and though this is the fifth time Charlotte

has died, my mother is crying again, and we're laughing
at her because we know nothing of loss and its sad math,
how every subtraction is exponential, how each grief

multiplies the one preceding it, how the author tried
seventeen times to record the words *She died alone*
without crying, seventeen takes and a short walk during

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which he called himself ridiculous, a grown man crying
for a spider he'd spun out of the silk thread of invention —
wondrous how those words would come back and make

him cry, and, yes, wondrous to hear my mother's voice
ten years after the day she died — the catch, the rasp,
the gathering up before she could say to us, *I'm OK*.

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